



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: The City School Fairmount
School Website: <https://cityschool.org/>

December 28, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

The City School – Fairmount Campus (Philadelphia, PA 19130) presents as a faith-based K–12 program with clear Christian identity and an emphasis on accessible urban education. The public-facing materials repeatedly frame the school as a Christian institution and highlight religious life components (e.g., Bible instruction, prayer-oriented content) alongside a broad curriculum (including STEAM, arts, languages, and athletics). However, there is minimal explicit articulation of classical education hallmarks such as the Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, Socratic pedagogy, *scholé* (restful contemplation), or a formal “living curriculum” approach. On balance, the public materials demonstrate a recognizable religious orientation and solid program offerings, but they do not consistently express the core six-element classical framework needed for a CLASSICAL rating in most categories.

Key observations driving the assessment:

- Strong Christian identity with Bible instruction and prayer-oriented materials (evidence: explicit Christian framing, Bible-related roles, and a page inviting prayer).
- Curriculum shown includes STEAM, arts, and language offerings, but no explicit Great Books, lecturing in the classical sense, or direct references to liberal arts as the Trivium/Quadrivium or to a “great conversation” framework. Public materials emphasize accessibility and Christian formation rather than classical method text.
- Pedagogical signals typical of classical education (Socratic seminars, *scholé* days, memory work, recitation, or rhetoric training) are not evident in the crawl materials. Lexicon-based negative signals for a non-classical trajectory (e.g., project-based learning dominance, experiential learning emphasis) are not central to the City School materials, but the absence of explicit classical pedagogy is notable. See classical-ity lexicon for reference on signs to watch for vs. signals present/absent.
- Faculty content appears in bios and job descriptions, but the language centers around standard school roles and faith-based community rather than a fully developed classical “living curriculum” or teacher-as-mentor paradigm per classical criteria.
- Parent and community language emphasizes accessibility and partnerships (admissions, financial aid, open-campus-style engagement) rather than a formal, cradle-to-grave classical parent formation program.

Overall assessment (aggregate): NOT CLASSICAL.

- The analysis below details category-by-category keyword analysis and scoring using the Six Essential Elements rubric, grounded in the classical lexicon, followed by the final ABSTRACT summary.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The City School presents itself as a K–12 Christian school, signaling a religious and metaphysical orientation (theology-inflected formation is implied via Bible-focused instruction and Christian community life). This is evidenced by explicit statements of Christian identity and Bible teaching roles within the school (e.g., HS Bible Teacher; Bible-focused staff bios) and a public invitation to prayer.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators relevant to Religious and Metaphysical Foundations in the classical lexicon (truth, goodness, beauty, theology, liturgy, etc.) appear indirectly through Christian

identity and prayer-oriented practices, but explicit terms like theology, liturgy, or classical metaphysical vocabulary are not consistently foregrounded in the public materials. The lexicon notes positive signals such as theology, liturgy, worship, and wonder, yet these appear only implicitly or in limited form here; the explicit words from the site that align with the lexicon are primarily “Christian” and “Bible” (and the prayer prompt). Positive keyword hits: limited to “Christian” and “Bible” and “prayer” signals; Negative hits: not evident.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates a religious framework and some communal spiritual practices, but it does not foreground the full spectrum of classical religious metaphysical indicators (e.g., explicit liturgical life, formal transcendentals, or a fully articulated theology curriculum beyond Bible instruction). Therefore this category is BEST characterized as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL, given the partial alignment with religious foundations but lacking explicit classical metaphysical articulation. The formal classical indicators such as liturgy, transcendental realism, and explicit theological integration into all disciplines are not clearly demonstrated in the public materials. See evidence and lexicon context above.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize accessibility and Christian formation; there is no explicit articulation of formation toward virtue, wisdom, or telos in the classical sense, nor a stated aim of pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty as universal ends beyond Christian formation. The phrases found emphasize accessibility and standard educational aims, not classical humanistic formation or contemplative aims. See general school statements about accessibility and Christian identity.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive classical indicators (formation; virtue; liberal education; scholé; pursuit of the true, good, beautiful) are not foregrounded in the public materials. Negative signals (career/workforce preparation emphasis) are not prominent in the text either, but the absence of classical formation signals dominates.

Why this rating - The school’s stated aim centers on accessibility and faith formation, not the classical paideia-driven goal of forming virtue and wisdom through liberal education and contemplation. The absence of explicit references to virtue formation, telos, or the Great Conversation supports a NOT CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Element 3: Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials show STEAM, arts, language offerings, and Christian content (Bible instruction). There is no explicit mention of liberal arts core cultures (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, or a sustained emphasis on history as a universal civilizational study (rather than “social studies” framing). The STEAM emphasis and Bible instruction suggest a broad curriculum but not a classical curriculum. The public materials do include “STEAM Letter” and “Art program,” etc.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive classical indicators (liberal arts, Great Books, history as a core discipline, classical languages) are not present; negative signals (project-based learning dominance) are not clearly stated in the site’s materials either, but the absence of classical curriculum signals is decisive.

Why this rating - There is no clear evidence of grammar-logic-rhetoric focus, no Great Books program, and no explicit emphasis on the liberal arts as a Trivium/Quadrivium path. The curriculum as shown aligns more with a broad, faith-integrated program rather than a classical liberal arts approach. Therefore NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials do not showcase Socratic seminars, scholé days, or a student-centered rhetorical pedagogy as core methods. The presence of job descriptions and general programming suggests conventional schooling models rather than a classical pedagogy built on memory work, recitation, or Socratic dialogue. The lexicon highlights Socratic seminars, recitation, and memory/chanting as canonical methods; the site does not foreground these as primary methods.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators from classical pedagogy (Socratic dialogue, rhetoric training, memory work, chanting) are not evidenced in the public postings. Negative indicators (experiential learning focus, project-based learning dominance) are not overtly signaled in the City School materials, but the absence of classic methods is a strong signal toward not-classical pedagogy.

Why this rating - The school's pedagogical language centers on faith-based instruction and standard K–12 schooling rather than a recovery or implementation of classical pedagogy (e.g., Socratic seminars, scholé, memory work). Therefore NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 5: Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty content in public materials includes staff bios and job descriptions; there is no explicit articulation of the Faculty as “living curriculum” or as exemplars in a classical sense, though staff are described in standard terms (mentors, bio pages, etc.). The lexicon notes that ideal classical faculties are “model teachers and mentors,” with a “living curriculum,” but these terms are not overtly claimed by the City School in the crawl data.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive signals such as “model teachers,” “living curriculum,” and “faculty of friends” are not directly present; instead, standard bios and roles are presented. Negative signals (certification-driven jargon without classical context) are not evident in the site data but are not contradicted by the data either.

Why this rating - While the school presents qualified staff and common professional roles, there is no explicit classical portrait of the teacher as the core living curriculum or as a “teacher as mentor” in a classical sense. Therefore NOT CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The City School materials describe admissions, financial aid, and family engagement in accessible terms, but they do not clearly articulate a parental formation program, co-teaching philosophy, or a strong liturgical-annual cycle for parent involvement. The materials emphasize parent access and involvement in general rather than a classical “co-teacher” model or parent formation programs on a sustained basis.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive classical indicators (partnerships with parents as co-teachers; parent formation groups, book clubs, etc.) are not foregrounded; the site emphasizes openness and admissions rather than a formal classical parent formation program. Negative signals from the classical lexicon would be low or absent in the data; however, the lack of explicit classical collaboration language signals NOT CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - Given the absence of classical-pedagogy-aligned parental/community engagement signals, this category is NOT CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- If the school aimed to move toward a CLASSICAL orientation, concrete steps could include:
 - Introduce and foreground a Trivium-based curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across grades, with explicit integration of primary classical texts and Great Books as foundational reading, coupled with a clear justification of how history, philosophy, and literature intersect.
 - Adopt formal scholé practices (restful learning days, contemplation, nature-based wonder) and clearly articulate contemplative pedagogy as a foundational element in lower and upper grades.
 - Implement Socratic seminars and structured seminars (Paideia-style) in upper grades, including public student oration, debates, and masterful rhetoric training aligned with a classical rhetoric sequence.
 - Elevate the faculty role as living curriculum with professional development focused on classical pedagogy, and present a clear portrait of the teacher as exemplar of virtue and intellectual leadership.

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- Develop explicit parent formation programs: classical book clubs, study groups, family liturgy guidelines, and open campus visits as a formal co-teaching model with the school, with regular community liturgical events and family participation in classical study.
 - Catalogue and emphasize a formal “Great Conversation” approach with a curated Great Books program (starting with selected classics and integrated discussions across disciplines).
 - Ensure public materials explicitly reference classical terms (truth, goodness, beauty; scholé; telos; virtue; liturgy; the Great Conversation) and demonstrate how the school's mission aligns with the classical framework.

Note: Because the aggregate classification is NOT CLASSICAL, the above “needle-moving” recommendations are provided as potential future enhancements rather than current requirements.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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